Is

Relation Without Time, Cause, or Rule

Matthew Parslow
Independent Researcher

Draft — draft-2026-08-30.3
30 August 2026 • document revision 17

Abstract

One claim, made without machinery. To be is to stand in relation, and nothing further is required for there to be anything at all — no sequence, no cause, no rule about what may follow what. The companion accounts begin after this point and say so; this one supplies what they begin after. It is short because there is very little to say once the claim is stated, and that shortness is the argument.

1 The claim

What is, is. That is the whole of it, and everything below is an attempt to say what the sentence commits to and what it does not.

To be *something* rather than nothing at all is to be distinguishable, and to be distinguishable is to stand apart from something. *Distinction is relation.* There is no third option in which a thing is determinate and stands in no relation whatever: such a thing would differ from nothing, and a thing that differs from nothing is not a thing but the absence of one.

Proposition 1.1 (To be is to be related)**.** *Anything that exists as a determinate something stands in at least one relation. Equivalently: an existent bearing no relation is indistinguishable from non-existence, and the distinction between them is not available to be drawn.*

2 Which is to say: a graph

The claim has a name, and refusing to use it would be coy. Relata standing in relations are nodes standing in edges. *Everything is a graph* — and that sentence is the whole thesis of the companion accounts, stated here in the only form that requires nothing to state it.

The question this paper asks is the dumbest one available: *what is there?* A child can ask it and nothing prevents anyone answering. It is also the largest, because an answer to it constrains every answer to anything else, and because there is nowhere further back to stand.

Two things follow about the form of this paper. It has *no machinery*, deliberately: no transformation, no grammar, no economics, no frames, nothing that could be disputed in place of the claim. Whatever a reader disagrees with here, it is the claim itself, which is the condition a first paper should meet and which no later one in this programme does.

And the objection that arrives immediately can be answered in a line. *Everything can be represented as a graph, so the claim is empty* — yes to the first clause, and the answer is that this is not a claim about representability. Nodes and edges are cheap; what is asserted is that there is *nothing else*, that relata and relations exhaust what there is, and that time and cause and rule in particular are not among the furniture. And the assertion is about *this* instance rather than about what is possible: a world with a global clock in its floor, or with production

as a primitive, is not prohibited by anything here — such a world could be built and would be perfectly coherent — the claim is that *this one is not that.* What would bear on it is therefore a demonstration that this world has such a floor, which is an empirical matter and not a modal one, and imagining a world that does costs nothing and settles nothing.

That is also why finding one would bound the account rather than refute it, in the way a later theory bounds an earlier: the claim would hold of worlds without such a floor and this would not be one of them. The companions argue all of this at length; here it is a paragraph, because here there is nothing else to argue about.

3 How the claim is reached

A claim of this shape is worth nothing if it arrives by assertion, and the difference between an account and a pronouncement is whether there is a procedure behind it that someone else can run. There is one here, it is short, and it is the reason this is science rather than a declaration about the world.

Ask at maximum scope. The question is put to everything at once rather than to a domain, because a shortest sufficient account of one domain tells you about that domain and a shortest sufficient account of all of it tells you what is common to all of it. The scope is what does the work: the more that must be accounted for, the more the structure peculiar to any part washes out and the more only what is shared survives.

Prefer the shortest account that suffices. Between two accounts covering the same ground, the one carrying less structure is preferred, and this is the ordinary discipline of minimum description length rather than anything invented here. Applied at maximum scope it has a direction: keep removing until removing costs coverage.

Remove, and see what breaks. This is the operation and it is the only one. Take a candidate — time, cause, rule, substance, an observer, a global clock — and put the account without it. If what was accounted for is still accounted for, the candidate was not required and it goes. If coverage is lost, it stays, and the loss shows what it was doing. Each removal is a test with a determinate outcome, which is what makes the procedure repeatable rather than a matter of taste.

Run that far enough and it stops in one place. Time can go: nothing in the claim requires sequence. Cause can go: relation is not production. Rule can go: nothing needs to be permitted or forbidden for things to stand as they stand. Relation cannot go, because removing it removes distinction, and removing distinction removes the possibility of there being determinate somethings for the account to be about at all. *The claim is not asserted here. It is what survived.*

A removal must be named and restorable. This is the discipline that separates the method from mere simplification, and it is the one place the procedure can be abused. Every account reached this way is an idealisation, and an idealisation is just a frame — which is no defence on its own, since everything is one. What makes a frame cheap to hold rather than expensive is whether what it removed is written down and can be put back. The rock is what this claim looks like at the grain at which it is a rock; that its atoms move and it weathers at other grains belongs on the same page, so the removed structure is recoverable and the idealisation costs little. *The spherical cow is not objectionable for being spherical.* It is objectionable when nobody writes down that it was made spherical, and the result is then applied to a cow.

The preference for the shortest sufficient account is not this programme's invention and runs in the same direction as information-theoretic and minimum-description-length practice: do not introduce structure that buys no additional distinction (Shannon, 1948; Rissanen, 1978). What is added here is only the scope at which it is applied.

Two honest limits on the method, and the second matters more.

Removal establishes that nothing *tried* was required, which is not the same as nothing being required. The result is only as good as the candidate list, so that list should be stated rather

than implied: time, causation, substance or intrinsic nature, an observer, a privileged frame or global clock, admissibility, and — less obviously — any axiom restricting where a distinction may be made from. That last is worth naming because it is easy to keep by habit: a rule that every distinction is made in some frame governs frames, and there are none here to govern. It arrives with the machinery it constrains, in the companion account, and is not required for anything this paper says. Anyone who thinks something else belongs at the base is invited to add it and run the same procedure, and that is the form disagreement with this paper should take.

And the procedure does not deliver certainty, only survival. A candidate that has not yet been removed successfully may still be removable by someone who sees how, and the account would then be shorter than it is here. That is not a defect to be apologised for; it is the direction the method runs in, and this paper expects to be shortened rather than extended.

4 A consequence with a track record

The claim fixes what compression is aiming at, and that turns out to be checkable in a way the claim itself is not.

If what there is, is relata standing in relations, then the shortest sufficient description of anything is relata standing in relations — because a description shorter than its subject's structure has lost something, and one longer is carrying what the subject does not have. *The ideal information shape is a graph*, not by stipulation but because the target of compression is fixed by what is being compressed. So a field pushing its own formalism toward minimum description should *move toward* graph form, and it should do so without anyone intending it.

That is a prediction about the history of formalisms rather than about the world, and it appears to hold: physics reaching for spin networks, tensor networks and causal sets; chemistry settling on the molecular graph; linguistics on dependency structure; computing on data structures that are graphs and on a categorical foundation that is arrows before objects; neuroscience on the connectome; biology on phylogenies and interaction networks. None of these was adopted because anybody held the thesis of this paper. Each was adopted because it was the cheapest thing that still accounted for the subject.

The discriminator matters and is easy to lose. *The prediction is about movement, not about drawability.* That a field's subject matter can be drawn as a graph shows nothing, since graphs are expressive and almost anything can be. What would count is a field that compressed its formalism and moved *away* from graph form — toward a primitive that is not a relatum or a relation and cannot be reduced to them — and that is what the second commitment below asks for.

5 One is not enough

A single relatum with nothing to relate to is not a minimal case of existence but a failed one. There is nothing for it to be distinguished from, so there is no fact about what it is; it does not sit at the bottom of the hierarchy of existing things, it fails to enter. *One relatum is decoherent.*

The empty case is the other end and is cleaner. Nothing at all stands in no relation, has no parts to be in tension, and admits no failure of fit — it is complete in the only sense available to it. That is why the empty set is the only perfect thing and why perfection is not something an existent can have: *to exist is to be imperfect*, because to exist is to be related, and to be related is to be partial with respect to what one is related to.

6 One direction only

A consequence of the restraint deserves its own statement, because it is what makes the claim's subject matter peculiar. *What merely is cannot observe; it can only be observed.*

To observe is to make a distinction, and making one is an act — something is done, and afterwards the observer holds what it did not hold before. That requires transformation and some grammar of what may follow what, and this paper has neither. So what is described here does nothing at all, and observing is among the things it does not do.

It can be the *object* of observation without difficulty, and in practice it is nothing else. A rock is what this looks like from outside: met, related to, distinguished by something that does have the machinery. But there is no corresponding inside. *There is no view from anywhere* — not a narrow view, not a limited one, none — because a view is something a frame has and what merely is is not a frame, and there are no frames here. The point is stronger than the familiar one and prior to it. The familiar claim is that there is no view from *nowhere* — that every view is had from somewhere, by someone positioned. That claim presupposes there are views, and asks where they are from. Here there are none to ask about: *no view from nowhere, and no view from anywhere either*, because a view is something a frame has and nothing here is a frame.

An axiom restricting where a distinction may be made from therefore cannot be stated at this level, let alone assumed. It needs views to exist before it can say where they are from, and it arrives with the machinery that has them.

Proposition 6.1 (Observation is one-directional at the base)**.** *What stands in relation without transformation or grammar can be observed and cannot observe. It is therefore always the object of a distinction and never the maker of one.*

7 What is not claimed

The claim above is smaller than it may appear, and the restraint is the point.

No time. Nothing here requires sequence. Relations hold; they do not happen. There is no earlier and no later in this paper, and no order in which anything is arrived at.

No cause. Nothing here makes anything else be. Relation is not production, and the account has no resources with which to say that one relatum brings about another.

No rule. Nothing here forbids anything or licenses anything. There is no admissibility, nothing that may or may not follow, and therefore nothing that could be violated.

Those three are not oversights and they are not deferred out of modesty. *They cost extra.* A world in which things also *happen* requires transformation and a grammar of what may follow what, and that is what the companion accounts introduce and pay for. This paper is what remains when they are removed, and it is offered as evidence that they are separable rather than constitutive.

8 Prior positions

None of this is new and it should not be dressed as though it were. The neighbours are easy to name. That relations are prior to, or on a level with, their relata is the ontic structural realist position (Ladyman and Ross, 2007; Esfeld, 2004); that a thing is nothing over and above what it stands in is older and starker (Nāgārjuna, 1995); and the bundle tradition reaches a neighbouring conclusion by a different route (Williams, 1978).

The relation to them is not the usual one, and the difference can be stated exactly rather than as a matter of emphasis. *Each of those accounts supposes a particular* ***type*** *of relation where the argument only requires that there be one.* Ontic structural realism is a thesis about physics — about what our best theories say the world is made of — so the relation carrying its

weight is measurement: an observer edge, running from something that theorises to something theorised about. The perspective literature does the same with an edge of viewing. Neither is mistaken about the structure; both are over-specified about the edge.

The removal is immediate and is the method's own. Take the observer edge out and put any other edge in its place — a gravitational one, a chemical bond, mere adjacency, one part of a rock against another — and everything the structural claim needs is still there. Two relata and a relation between them do not care which relation it is. So what those accounts treat as constitutive is a *choice of edge type*, salient in the domains they were written for and doing no work in the claim itself; and what survives removing it is the claim this paper makes.

The same over-specification is visible in the two fields that own this vocabulary, which is worth saying because they are the ones a reader will expect to have settled the matter. Information theory defines its quantities over a source and a channel: there is something sending, something receiving, and a distribution over what might have been sent. That is an observer edge again, wearing different clothes, and it is why entropy is a property of a source-and-receiver arrangement rather than of a thing. And graph theory, in its standard presentation, takes a vertex set first and defines edges as pairs drawn from it — which builds in the priority of relata over relations before any question about that priority has been asked. Neither field is careless. Each fixed an edge type or an order of construction because its own problems required one.

Which yields the deflationary version of this whole paper. *If everything is a graph, then the minimum structure required to be a graph is the minimum structure required, full stop.* That structure is not something this paper discovers: it has been written down in every textbook of the subject for a century, as relata and relations and nothing else. What is being done here is not deriving it but *taking it seriously* — reading a definition that was built as a formalism as though it were an answer to the largest question, and then checking that nothing else has to be added. The removals above are that check. That is the entire contribution, and it is smaller than it sounds while being, if the claim holds, sufficient.

One qualification even there, and it is not a criticism of the formalism. The textbook definition takes a vertex set as given and edges as pairs over it, which makes relata prior — and it does so for a good reason. *Graph theory's objects do not need to exist.* They are built, and building takes an order: you must have the vertices in hand before you can say which pairs of them are edges. The priority is a feature of *construction*, and construction is what mathematics does.

Nothing here is constructed. What exists was not assembled in an order, and there is no stage at which the relata were available and the relations not yet drawn. So the priority does not merely go unneeded in this paper — it is *unavailable*, and for a reason already established: an order of construction is a sequence, and there is no time here for one to run in. A definition that builds cannot be read as a description of something that was never built without carrying its scaffolding across.

Which sharpens the earlier point rather than softening it. Graph theory is not over-specified for its own purposes; it is exactly specified for constructing objects. What does not transfer is the scaffolding, and noticing that it is scaffolding is most of the work of taking the definition seriously.

That is also why the closest neighbour is the one furthest from physics. Nāgārjuna (1995) makes the claim without an observer edge anywhere in it — nothing needs to be looking, measuring or theorising for a thing to be nothing over and above what it stands in — which is the property the others lack, and which only became the discriminating one once the edge type was seen to be removable.

There remains the fact that this is simple enough to state in a sentence and appears not to have been stated, which invites the reaction that it must therefore be either trivial or wrong. The account has its own explanation for that pairing and it is in the companion on assessment, so a short one will do here, and the short one is structural rather than a remark about incentives.

People do not study everything. They study something. A field is constituted by its restriction — what it attends to and what it sets aside — and a field with no restriction is not a field. So the question this paper asks, which has to be put at maximum scope or it is not the same question, belongs to no discipline: there is no subject matter of which it is the subject matter, and no method calibrated for it, because every method is calibrated to a something.

The restriction is not merely conceptual either; it is enforced by everything that produces written work. The shortest statement of it is a conversation. *"I would like a research grant." "What are you studying?" "Everything."* There is no dishonest answer available there, and no fundable one. The same exchange happens at a journal, at a department, and on any hiring committee, because each is asking the question that constitutes a field and receiving the one answer that does not name one.

None of which is a complaint, and it should not be read as one: the restriction is what makes fields work, and an arrangement that funded everything would fund nothing. What it explains is only what such an arrangement does not produce, which is the general form — and that is why the general form goes unwritten while every local version gets written well. It also explains, without needing a separate reason, why such statements tend to arrive from someone crossing between domains: crossing is what asking at maximum scope looks like from inside an arrangement where every position is a restricted one.

The claim of absence should be held loosely, though, and more loosely than the rest of the paper. It is the kind of claim this programme has repeatedly got wrong, always in the same direction — the prior art nearer than expected — and the sentence above is one nobody could be confident of having searched exhaustively. It is offered as an invitation: if this has been written down as a claim about what exists, rather than as a formalism or as a thesis within one field, the right response to this paper is the reference.

What is contributed is accordingly not the thesis but its *position*: that it is enough on its own; that time, cause, rule, an observer, and any axiom about where distinctions may be made from are not required for it; and that an account of how things change can be built on top without folding any of them back in. The companion papers are that account, and their first move is to assume this one.

9 Falsifiability

Two commitments. The first is what the paper claims; the second is what the claim predicts, and is the easier of the two to test.

1. [SHAPE] **To be is to be related.** A claim about this instance and not about every possible one. Fails on the exhibition of an extant something standing in no relation whatever — not merely one whose relations are unknown or unmeasured, which is the ordinary condition of most things, but one for which the claim that it stands in any relation at all is false. The burden is entirely on that side: no enumeration establishes the claim, since the domain does not terminate, and one instance would bound it.

2. [SHAPE] **Compression moves toward graph form.** A consequence of the first and easier to test. Fails if a field, pushing its own formalism toward the shortest account that still suffices, moves *away* from relata-and-relations — adopting under compression pressure a primitive that is neither, and that does not reduce to them. Expressiveness is not at issue: that a subject *can* be drawn as a graph is no evidence, and only the direction of movement under compression counts.

One objection to that commitment has to be met, because an earlier version of this section raised it and was wrong. It runs: exhibiting a counterexample means observing it, observing

relates it to the observer, so anything offered as unrelated is related by the act of being offered, and the falsifier cannot be met.

That slides from *relation* to *observation*, and the two are not the same. *Observation is not required for existence.* The tree falls in the empty forest and stands in relation throughout — to the ground it strikes, to the air it moves, to its own fibres as they part — and not one of those relations waits on anybody looking. Observation is a *kind* of relation, and a late and expensive one, since it requires a frame with the machinery to make a distinction; relation is the general case and requires nothing.

So the claim here is not that to be is to be perceived, which is a different thesis with a different name and is not held. What is claimed is that to be is to be *related*, and the falsifier asks for something standing in no relation whatever — not for something unobserved, of which there is a great deal. That makes the commitment harder to meet rather than easier, since a candidate cannot be rescued by pointing out that it is now related to whoever produced it: the question is whether it stood in any relation at all, and the fallen tree settles that without an observer anywhere.

Proposition 6.1 survives this unchanged. What merely is still cannot observe. It simply does not follow that it needs to be observed in order to be.

A second thing would count against the paper without falsifying the proposition, and is worth stating separately: if time, cause, or rule turned out not to be separable — if the account of change built on this one could not be constructed without folding one of them back into the base — then the restraint claimed in Section 3 would be a fiction and this paper would be an incomplete statement of the base rather than a minimal one.

References

Claude E. Shannon. A mathematical theory of communication. *Bell System Technical Journal*, 27:379–423, 623–656, 1948.

Jorma Rissanen. Modeling by shortest data description. *Automatica*, 14:465–471, 1978.

Michael Esfeld. Quantum entanglement and a metaphysics of relations. *Studies in History and Philosophy of Modern Physics*, 35(4):601–617, 2004.

James Ladyman and Don Ross. *Every Thing Must Go: Metaphysics Naturalized.* Oxford University Press, Oxford, 2007.

Nāgārjuna. *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way: Nāgārjuna's Mūlamadhyamakakārikā.* Translated by Jay L. Garfield. Oxford University Press, New York, 1995.

Bernard Williams. *Descartes: The Project of Pure Enquiry.* Penguin, Harmondsworth, 1978.